

Explain an unfamiliar idea

Learner workbook

Help a listener understand a new term.

Understand the distinction

Start with a familiar category, then describe the defining feature and give a concrete example. A commuter is a person who regularly travels between home and work. The example should clarify the definition, not replace it.

Adjust the detail to the listener. Ask what they already know and check understanding with a useful question. Avoid explaining one unfamiliar word through several more unfamiliar words. An analogy helps only if you also state where it differs.

Compare the patterns

CATEGORY

A library is a place where people can borrow books.

Start with a familiar kind of thing.

EXAMPLE

You can borrow a novel and return it later.

Make the activity concrete.

CHECK

How is borrowing different from buying?

Ask about the important distinction.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Which opening is clearer for a beginner: A commuter is a person ... / A commuter is an intermodal participant ...?

- A. Both are equally easy for every beginner.
- B. A commuter is an intermodal participant ...
- C. A commuter is a person ...

2. Which sentence explains borrow?

- A. Borrow means give someone something for a time.
- B. Borrow means use something for a time and then return it.
- C. Borrow means keep something permanently without returning it.

3. Why might an example alone be insufficient?

- A. It may not show what all uses have in common.
- B. An example always gives a complete definition.
- C. Definitions should never contain examples.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which explanation gives a beginner a simple category and the basic use of a delivery locker?

A. A delivery locker is an asynchronous fulfillment endpoint.

B. A delivery locker is a secure place to collect a package. You use a code to open its door.

C. A delivery locker is a place where you buy a package and choose its contents.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. A commuter is a person ...

A familiar category gives the listener a starting point.

2. B. Borrow means use something for a time and then return it.

Include the temporary use and expected return.

3. A. It may not show what all uses have in common.

A short definition gives the general meaning.

4. B. A delivery locker is a secure place to collect a package. You use a code to open its door.

The explanation identifies the kind of place and gives a concrete action.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-42.html